SOP-IT-006 · Renaming a local folder: what is filed under its old name, and how to move it all

SOP IT-006 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-06 | For Anyone who works with a helper on their own machine

Department: IT · **ID:** 006 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** the lab steward · **Last changed:** 2026-11-06

Purpose

Renaming a folder looks harmless, and to git it is: a clone doesn't care what its folder is called. But other things on your machine are filed by the folder's **full path**, and a rename quietly cuts them off. This page says what they are, and how to move a folder so nothing is stranded. Nothing is deleted by a careless rename. The history just gets hard to find, which on a bad day is nearly the same.

Scope

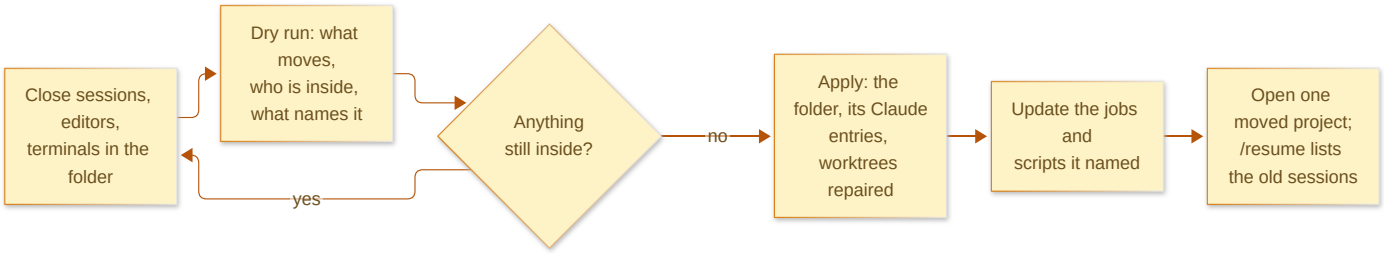
Any local folder holding a repository, or holding folders of them, on a machine where Claude Code, launchd jobs or editors work in it. Renaming a repository **on GitHub** is a different job, and GitHub redirects its old address.

What a rename cuts off

Filed by path	What you would notice	What fixes it
Claude Code's sessions and memory, `~/.claude/projects/<the path, flattened>/`	`/resume` no longer lists your old sessions, and saved memory stops loading: Claude greets the folder as a brand-new project	move that folder too
Everything inside a renamed parent. Each subfolder has its own project entry	a session in a child repo is orphaned though you only renamed the parent	move every child entry too
Scheduled jobs (launchd agents, cron) and scripts with a hard-coded path	a job fails at night, possibly silently	update the path; give the job a failure alert
Linked git worktrees record absolute paths both ways	`fatal: not a git repository` inside a worktree	`git worktree repair`
Open editors and terminals hold the old folder	VS Code shows stale files; a terminal sits in a folder that "no longer exists"	close them first, reopen after
Documents and handoffs naming the path	a helper follows a dead path and gets confused	search and update the ones in use; leave dated history as it was

The flattening trap. Claude Code turns every character but a letter or a digit into `-`, so `~/code/pir/foo` and `~/code/pir-foo` both become `...-code-pir-foo`. A move by name alone can take the wrong folder's history. Check what is inside first: each session file records the real working folder in a `cwd` field.

The move



Steps

1. **Dry run.** `python3 -I my-template/scripts/rename-local-repo.py OLD NEW --ref <folder of scripts to check>`. *You should see:* the Claude project folders it would move, anything it left alone and why, what is working inside the folder now, and which files still name the old path. It changes nothing.
2. **Close what it names:** Claude sessions in that folder or below, VS Code windows, terminals. A job due to run soon counts: don't rename at 23:50 if a job runs at 23:55.
3. **Read what it left alone.** A project folder is left alone when its sessions name a different path. That may be a real name collision, or the mark of an earlier move. Look before you vouch for it with `--adopt=<name>` (the `=` form, because the name starts with a dash).
4. **Apply.** Add `--apply`. It refuses while anything is still inside. *You should see:* "moved", and how many repositories had worktrees repaired.
5. **Update the paths it named,** and restart any launchd agent whose plist changed (`launchctl unload` then `load`, by hand, once).
6. **Prove it.** Open the moved project in Claude Code and run `/resume`. *You should see:* the old sessions. Then run `git status` in a worktree, and check the next scheduled job's result in the morning.

What it never does

It deletes nothing. It does not edit transcripts, so an old session still records the old path in its history, and that is true history. It does not rename anything on GitHub.

If it already happened

Nothing is lost. Your old sessions sit in `~/.claude/projects/` under the old flattened name. Move that folder to the new flattened name and `/resume` finds them again.

Worked example, Nov 6, 2026

The lab's own renames, written down so others know how this is done. **Eight folders:** seven labs under `~/code/` were to take a `-lab` suffix (`pir` became `pir-lab`, `the-holy-earth-foundation` became `the-holy-earth-foundation-lab`, and so on), and one organisation folder was to drop its `-org` (`~/taylordwraps-org` became `~/taylordwraps`).

1. **The dry run first, for all eight,** before anything moved. It listed each folder's Claude project entries (a parent and every child inside it), the scripts that still named the old paths, and what was working in each folder right then.
2. **A VS Code window held one back.** One lab was still open in an editor window, so the apply refused that folder. The other seven went ahead. The eighth waits until its window is closed, then runs on its own; nothing is lost by waiting.
3. **Parked Terminal tabs.** Several tabs sat idle in folders being renamed, with nothing running in them. `--allow-idle-shells` lets the apply go past a shell that is only sitting there (macOS keeps it working through the move, still showing the old path). A program running in the folder still stops it. Afterwards, `cd` to the new name in such a tab before typing `claude`.
4. **Two vouches, in the `=` form.** The dry run left two project folders alone because their sessions named another path: the mark of an earlier move, checked by reading their `cwd` fields. Both were vouched for with `--adopt=NAME`. Write the `=`: a project folder's name starts with a dash (`-Users-...`), and after a space the name reads as another option.

5. **Seven sessions found only in an archive.** Seven old sessions sat only in `~/.claude/projects/_archived-pre-move-sessions/`, filed under paths that had not existed since earlier moves, so `/resume` could list them nowhere. They were **copied, not moved,** into the project folders of their repositories' current homes. The archive stays as it was.
6. **The nightly job, before its run.** The nightly job named two paths inside a renamed lab. Both were fixed the same day, before its next run, so it never had the chance to fail at night.

Related

`my-template/NESTED-REPOS-GUIDE.md` (where clones live), SOP-OPS-003 (the lanes), `scripts/clone-map.sh` (where everything is now). *Read Nov 5, 2026 from the machine itself; Claude Code may change how it files projects, so re-check `~/.claude/projects/` if this page ever seems wrong.*

Change log

Date	Change
2026-11-05	Drafted before the lab's own renames, from a heads-up about orphaned sessions.
2026-11-06	A worked example from the lab's renames that day; `--adopt=` written with its `=`.

Part of the fleet's procedures. The master copies and the legend live in my-template.